because of the Mughal Empire, which created new travel opportunities for pilgrims, scholars and traders. Political unification gave the pilgrim a high 'degree of security on his journey; and the state had a positive interest in promoting this freedom of travel in that it derived substantial revenues from trade and pilgrim taxes'.[13]

Varanasi suffered setbacks too. According to historian Richard Eaton, two campaigns of temple desecration took place: one each under Shah Jahan and Aurangzeb. Hindu nationalists today allege thousands of temple desecrations in Varanasi over many more Mughal campaigns, which, while possible, lack scholarly evidence.[14] By and large, the Mughals, writes Eaton, treated temples in their domain as state property and 'undertook to protect both the physical structures and their Brahmin functionaries'.[15] The temples they destroyed, argues Eaton, were far fewer and usually politically salient for their association with rival Hindu kings, who drew their divine right to rule by patronizing these temples.[16] Most desecrations had political and not sectarian motives. Such nuance, however, remains a bone in the kebab of Hindu nationalism.

In reality, under Muslim rule, realpolitik greatly overshadowed sectarian motives. All Mughal emperors had Hindu administrators and Rajput and Maratha allies and soldiers, which curbed sectarianism. The Mughals fought brutal wars against other Muslims, such as of Bijapur and Golconda; perhaps the deadliest massacres of Hindus in this period were carried out by the Hindu Marathas in Bengal.[17] Akbar actively supported Hinduism, interfaith dialogue and multiculturalism; his Rajput allies built many temples and ghats in Varanasi. Forced conversions remained rare.[18] A sizable minority in Varanasi, especially lower-caste, voluntarily converted to Islam, drawn to its promise of spiritual equality among all believers and the mundane benefits of practising the rulers' faith, such as better job prospects, easier employment in the army and avoiding *jizya* (see below).[19] Many converts were lower-caste weavers, or *julaha*s, including Kabir's parents.

It would of course be foolish to argue that every temple desecration had purely political motives. In some cases, sectarian motives mattered too,